

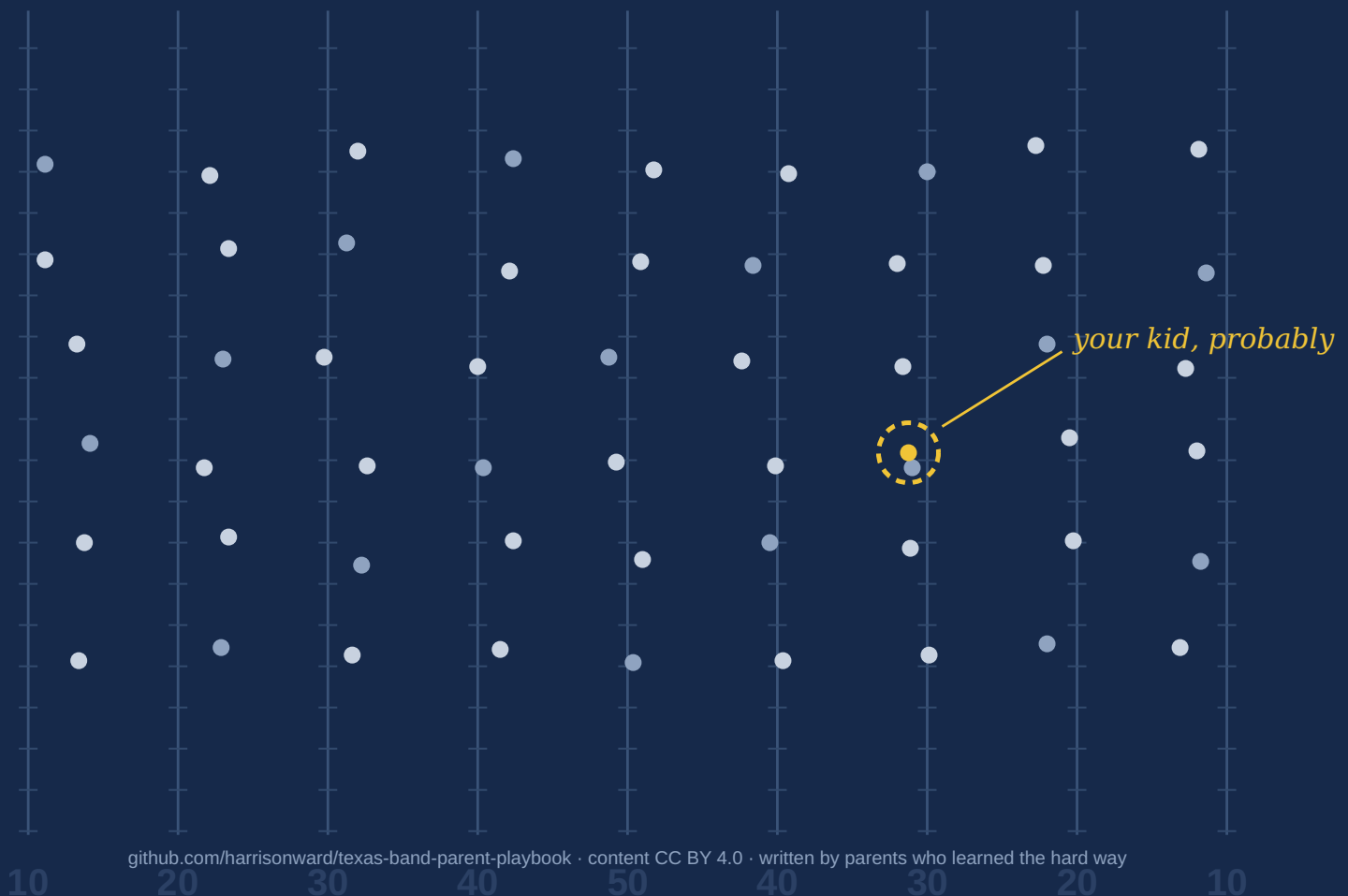
SET 1 · OPENER · HOLD 16 COUNTS

# THE TEXAS BAND PARENT PLAYBOOK

*Plain-English survival guides for marching band  
and color guard families. No pep talks.*

FLOWER MOUND EDITION · FALL 2026 · 22 GUIDES

Legend: ● performer ○ open set × parent, lost, see page 1



## What's inside

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1. So Your Kid Joined the Band
2. Every App You Actually Need
3. Common Questions, Blunt Answers
4. The WISK Digest
5. Calendars
6. The Band Dictionary
7. Contest Day Survival
8. The Money Guide
9. Winter Guard 101
10. The Friday Night Guide
11. All-Region 101
12. The Volunteer Field Guide
13. The Freshman Year Timeline
14. Winter Percussion 101
15. The Grandma Page
16. The Health Page
17. The Instrument Buying Guide
18. Records and Receipts
19. The Middle School Pipeline
20. Contacts and Connections
21. Forms and Quick Links
22. Lettering in Band
23. Contributing

# So Your Kid Joined the Band

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*A starter guide for new Texas band and color guard parents*

Nobody hands you a manual when your kid comes home signed up for marching band. This is that manual, from a family that went from middle school orchestra straight into a competition band and a world class color guard with zero warning. No speeches about the transformative power of the activity. Just what happens, what it costs, and what you need to do, with sources at the bottom.

Written for Texas. Dates below are for the fall 2026 season. Rules and fees drift, so trust your director's emails over anything on the internet, including this.

## TL;DR

### Buy:

- Gallon jug
- Athletic shoes, tall socks
- Sunscreen, hat
- Carry-on suitcase with wheels
- Travel power strip
- Multi-port charger (Anker type)
- AirTags for every bag
- Reloadable debit card
- Snack box for the band bag
- One Sharpie, label everything
- The merch
- Weapon kid flying? A long gun case with real locks
- An oil change and tire rotation. You are the logistics department now.

### Expect:

- Band camp in August heat. Normal.
- Physical on file before they march. Medical history form every year.
- A few hundred to \$1,500+ a year. Payment plans exist. Ask.
- Fridays gone. October Saturdays gone.
- Driving 8 hours to a comp and seeing your kid for 10 minutes as they walk to the bus.
- 15 early is on time. Pickup runs 20 to 30 late.
- No single source of truth. Find a veteran parent.
- Bus back at 2 a.m., first period at 8. They survive.
- The 8-hour rule slows it down once school starts. August is the worst of it.
- Feeling lost your whole first semester. Everyone is.
- Volunteer or you will not see your kid until Thanksgiving.

## Band camp, or why your kid smells like that

Texas bands ease in before August 1 because UIL only allows 15 hours of supervised marching fundamentals before that date, and wind players cannot learn the competitive show's choreography yet. On August 1 that restriction lifts and UIL sets no practice limits until the first day of school. That is why early August is wall-to-wall rehearsal. It is not your director freelancing. It is the calendar every band in the state runs.

What your kid actually needs:

- A gallon water jug with their name on it, in Sharpie. This is the one non-negotiable purchase. Skip the stick-on labels, they peel. Sharpie everything, actually.
- Kitchen tip: a pot filler or bathtub faucet fills a gallon jug in seconds. The fridge door will take all morning.
- The band tea stop is a lifestyle. Around here it is HTeaO. Sign up for the rewards program on day one, you are going to fund it either way.
- Athletic shoes and tall socks. Never sandals, never slides, even on “light” days.
- Sunscreen, a hat, sunglasses, and a real breakfast before they leave.
- A box of packable snacks that lives in the band bag and gets restocked weekly.
- A black towel. The handbook literally requires one. Ask your kid what it’s for, they’ll know by day two.
- Dinner ready and low expectations for conversation afterward.

Programs handle the heat with scheduled water breaks, shade, and indoor blocks. If your kid has a health condition, tell the directors before camp, not after something happens.

One more thing nobody tells orchestra families: big programs field more than one band (JV and varsity) and several guard levels, placed by audition. Prior marching experience is not required for any of it. Kids walk in cold as freshmen and land fine.

### Paperwork before they march

Texas requires a pre-participation physical for marching band, on the UIL’s standardized form, upon entering 9th grade and 11th grade, and for any 7th or 8th grader who marches. A medical history form signed by you and your kid is due every single year. Clinics book up in July, so knock this out in June if you can. Your band will send the exact forms and the deadline.

### What it actually costs

Every program posts its own numbers, and they vary a lot by district and by how far the band travels. Ask for the fee sheet before registration day so nothing surprises you. For scale, one large Houston-area program (Cypress Creek) charges \$500 for band and \$450 for guard in 2026-27, which covers about 15 game-day and contest meals, show shirts, uniforms, entry fees, and instruction.

| Cost             | Typical shape             | Notes                                              |
|------------------|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Band fee         | a few hundred dollars     | usually covers meals, shirts, entries, instruction |
| Guard fee        | similar, sometimes higher | costumes and equipment are in there                |
| Marching shoes   | \$30 to \$60              | plus gloves for most sections                      |
| Instrument costs | varies widely             | school rental fees, reeds, valve oil, sticks       |
| Private lessons  | \$25 to \$40 each         | optional but common in big programs                |
| Trip years       | can add \$500 to \$2,000  | not every year, announced far ahead                |

Three things nobody says loudly enough: payment plans are standard, most programs have a quiet hardship process (one email to the director, handled discreetly, they have done it many times), and fundraisers are real money, not busywork.

### Where your weekends went

Friday nights, all season: football. The band plays halftime and the stands. Your kid is there from afternoon call time until close to midnight.

Saturdays from mid-September through early November: contests. Texas has two worlds, and your band may live in one or both.

**UIL** is the school league. Bands advance Region, then Area, then State, at the Alamodome in San Antonio. Every classification now competes at State every year. That changed recently, so veteran parents may still tell you it alternates years. They are out of date, which will delight them. In 2026, conferences 1A/3A/5A go November 2 to 4 and 2A/4A/6A go November 9 to 11.

**BOA (Bands of America)** is a national circuit many Texas bands also enter. In 2026 there are eight Texas regionals from mid-September through late October (McAllen, Bedford, Shenandoah, Iowa Colony, San Marcos, Prosper, Midland, Waco), then the San Antonio Super Regional at the Alamodome on November 6 and 7.

Contest days run long. Prelims in the morning, finals at night if the band advances, home very late. Buy the ticket, bring a stadium seat, and clap for every band. Yes, admission costs money. Welcome to the sport.

## Band time

Call time means 15 minutes early, and the program means it. The posted end time gets no such respect. Expect 20 to 30 minutes past it, most days. Park, queue up a podcast, make peace.

## The 8-hour rule, or why it gets better

Starting the fourth Monday in August (slightly different for early-start districts), UIL caps marching band rehearsal at 8 hours per week outside the school day. Performances and football games do not count against it, and there is an extra hour allowed on performance days. Practical translation: after camp, life settles into a couple of evening or morning rehearsals a week plus Friday games and some Saturdays. The August pace is temporary, by rule.

One asterisk from lived experience: programs use every minute the rule allows, and games, contests, and performance days sit outside the cap. The rule limits rehearsal. It does not limit band.

## If your band travels

Competition bands get on buses. Some get on planes. Field notes from a traveling family:

- Buy a good carry-on size suitcase with wheels. They will drag it across four parking lots in the dark.
- Hotel rooms run four kids deep and outlets are scarce. Send a travel power strip.
- Each kid charges about five things a night (phone, iPad, headphones, battery pack). A multi-port charger, Anker or similar, ends the outlet wars.
- AirTags in every bag. Buses and equipment trucks eat luggage.
- A debit or prepaid card you can reload from your phone beats an envelope of cash.
- They will sleep badly on a bus and perform anyway. I have watched 500 kids too tired to stand walk onto a field and put up a clean run. No mistakes. Nobody can explain it.
- You will drive 8 hours to a contest and see your kid for 10 minutes while they walk to the bus. You will do it again the next weekend, on purpose.
- The bus unloads at the school at 2 a.m. and they go to first period. This is real and somehow survivable.
- Make peace with your kid riding to rehearsals and games with other teenagers. It will simplify your life more than any other single decision.

## Color guard, specifically

- Guard performs with the band in the fall and is scored as part of the band. Same contests, same bus.
- Big programs field multiple guards, sometimes four levels up through world class. Placement is by audition and prior band experience is not required. Dance and gymnastics kids convert fast.
- “Weapon” means rifle and sabre, the equipment that spins and gets thrown. Making the weapon line is a big deal. When your kid says they are a weapon, congratulate them.
- If your weapon kid wants to practice on vacation, you will end up buying an actual long rifle gun case, because nothing else fits a guard rifle. The airline does not care that it is a wooden prop. Expect the full firearm treatment: hard case, real locks, questions at the counter, and a 16 year old learning to check it solo like a seasoned roadie.
- Equipment is flags, rifles, and sabres. The rifle is a wooden or plastic prop. Nothing fires.
- UIL lets guard start show choreography earlier in the summer than wind players, so guard camp may start before band camp. That is legal and normal.
- Costs lean different: costume, gloves, shoes, makeup kit, sometimes hair pieces. The fee sheet will spell it out.
- Many programs also do winter guard, an indoor season from roughly December through April. In North Texas the local circuit is NTCA (North Texas Colorguard Association). Much of the rest of the state runs TCGC (Texas Color Guard Circuit). WGI is the national circuit, and its World

Championships run in Dayton, Ohio every April. Separate fee, separate calendar, and if the guard is good, a plane ticket. Ask in the fall whether your program competes in winter so spring does not ambush you.

### What this looks like in practice: Flower Mound

Our program, for scale. Flower Mound HS (Lewisville ISD, 6A) runs around 430 band kids across four concert ensembles, a varsity Competition Band of roughly 200, and the Jaguar Band. The guard program tops out at world class, with World and National A winterguards in the spring. The fall resume includes UIL 6A State gold in 2016 and 2025, three BOA Grand Nationals finalist runs, and four BOA San Antonio Super Regional titles. In winter the guards compete in NTCA around DFW and in WGI, whose season ends in Dayton every April. For real numbers: the 2026-27 band fee here is \$700 with a \$250 deposit. The resume also includes marching the Macy's Thanksgiving Day Parade in 2024, which tells you the ceiling on where a Texas band season can go.

The point is not to brag on one school. The point is that programs like this exist all over Texas, your kid can walk into one as a freshman with zero marching experience, and the machine knows exactly what to do with them. Ours did.

### How to actually help

- Get on the communication app the first week (Cut Time, BAND, Remind, whatever your program uses), then accept that no single channel has the whole picture. Cross-check the app, the student group chat, and one veteran parent. If you feel lost your first semester, you are on schedule. Everyone is.
- Feed them, hydrate them, wash the show shirt on Thursday nights.
- Volunteer early: props and pit crew (you get on the field), uniforms, meals, chaperoning. Pick one thing per season and do it well. It is also the main way you will actually see your kid between August and November.
- One catch on volunteering: most districts require a background check first (LISD runs it through a portal called VOLY) and it can take two weeks to clear. File it in July, not the week you want to help.
- Do not coach from the fence. You will want to. The staff saw it too.
- Do not forget the siblings. A contest is a very long day for a very short show, and nobody has to attend all of them. Let the other kids skip some, and put something on the calendar that is theirs alone.
- Buy the merch. There is a lot of it, it is better than you expect, and showing up in school colors matters to your kid more than they will admit.
- The booster board is regular parents running what amounts to a small company budget, for free, because somebody has to. Go to one meeting before you form opinions. Better, take a small job.
- Start-of-season car care: oil change, tire rotation. You are about to put real miles on dark highways.

### Small glossary

The ten-word survival version. The full Band Dictionary has the rest, from masterclass to Midwest Clinic.

| Word                 | Meaning                                                               |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Drill / sets         | the choreography of where everyone stands, learned as numbered pages  |
| Dot                  | your kid's exact spot on the field in a given set                     |
| Pit / front ensemble | the mallet and percussion instruments parked in front of the field    |
| Battery              | the drumline that marches                                             |
| Drum major           | the student conductor on the podium                                   |
| The box              | where the judges sit, top of the stands                               |
| Region / Area        | the UIL rounds before State                                           |
| Prelims / finals     | morning performance, then an evening performance if the band advances |
| "One more time"      | a lie, plan on three                                                  |

## Sources

- UIL State Marching Band Contest, dates and format
- UIL Eight Hour Rule FAQ
- UIL Summer Marching Band Practice Rules
- UIL Section 1105, physical exam requirement
- Bands of America 2026 schedule
- Cypress Creek HS band fees, 2026-27
- NTCA, North Texas Colorguard Association
- TCGC, Texas Color Guard Circuit
- WGI Sport of the Arts
- Flower Mound HS Band, program info
- Flower Mound HS Color Guard

Fee figures and dates checked August 2026. If you are reading this later, verify against the links.

# Every App a Flower Mound Band Parent Actually Needs

*The FMHS band and guard digital stack, in one giant list*

The program runs on more platforms than most companies and nobody hands you the list. Here it is, pulled from the band site, the booster page, the LISD district pages, and three seasons of posts in the guard parents Facebook group, checked August 2026. Items marked with a \* are common in the program but not posted anywhere official, so confirm with a veteran parent.

## The must-haves, set these up in week one

| Platform                               | What it is                               | What you will use it for                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Presto Assistant                       | The band's student management system     | The roster of record: even the parent Facebook groups check you against it before letting you in. Also handles the calendar, forms, district instrument rental paperwork and fees, and the weekly email newsletter everyone calls the WISK. Replaced Charms around 2024, so when a veteran parent says "check Charms," they mean this. |
| Skyward Family Access                  | LISD's parent portal                     | Grades, attendance, annual enrollment                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| RevTrak                                | LISD's payment site, linked from Skyward | School-side fee payments                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Rank One                               | LISD's forms portal                      | Physicals and medical history paperwork for UIL activities                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| VOLY                                   | LISD's volunteer portal                  | Annual background check, required before helping at any band activity. Takes up to two weeks, so file it before you plan to say yes to anything. Link comes through the WISK.                                                                                                                                                          |
| Google Forms and Drive                 | The band's document layer                | The UIL physical form gets submitted through a Google Form, and the band handbook lives on Drive. Links come from the band.                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| BAND                                   | Group communication app                  | The guard's official channel: liaisons answer questions there and uniform pickup notices go out through it. Guard families, download it day one.                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Canvas                                 | LISD's class platform                    | Mostly your kid's homework world, but band registration emails have landed there too                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| fmhsband.org                           | The band website                         | Schedules, FAQ, band camp packing list, pickup procedures, booster info                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
| Band Google Calendars: one, two, three | The season, hour by hour                 | The band runs a General calendar plus one per group. Subscribe to General and your kid's groups in Google Calendar and every rehearsal, game, and contest lands on your phone automatically.                                                                                                                                           |

## Game and contest weekends

| Platform                  | What you will use it for                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| HomeTown Ticketing        | Football game tickets, the LISD box office                                                                                                 |
| Ticketmaster              | UIL State Marching Band Contest tickets at the Alamodome                                                                                   |
| FloMarching               | Paid streaming for BOA and WGI events, for the weekends you cannot make the drive                                                          |
| musicforall.org           | BOA schedules, results, and logistics                                                                                                      |
| uiltexas.org              | UIL rules, dates, and contest info                                                                                                         |
| SmugMug                   | Free competition galleries shot by parent photographers. Bookmark it, your kid is in there somewhere.                                      |
| Jolesch Photography       | Where you buy the official BOA band photo                                                                                                  |
| Google Maps live location | On big trips the crew has shared a live pin so parents could watch the equipment trucks roll across the country. Peak band parent content. |



## Money and merch

| Platform                        | What you will use it for                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| FMHS Band Store on Square       | The band merch. There is a lot and it is good.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| FMHS Colorguard Store on Square | The guard's own store: uniforms, show shirts, merch, earrings. QR codes show up on posts.                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| JotForm                         | The big one for paperwork with money attached: registration, deposits, photo orders, patch orders, plus booster donations and reimbursements. For scale, the 2026-27 band fee ran through it: \$250 deposit, \$700 total. Links arrive through official channels and the boosters page. |
| SignUpGenius                    | Volunteer slots and meal signups: home game meals, NTCA championship shifts                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| SurveyMonkey                    | The old pit crew signup tool, mostly retired in favor of SignUpGenius                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Venmo and Zelle                 | The parent-to-parent layer: chipping in for team meals, Boo Buckets, the occasional water balloon fight                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Checks                          | Old school still works: payable to FMHS Band Boosters, except private lessons which go to the teacher                                                                                                                                                                                   |

## Social, follow all of it

| Account                   | Where                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Band Facebook             | <a href="https://facebook.com/flowermoundband">facebook.com/flowermoundband</a>                                                                                        |
| Band Instagram            | <a href="https://instagram.com/flowermoundband">instagram.com/flowermoundband</a>                                                                                      |
| Band X/Twitter            | <a href="https://twitter.com/flowermoundband">twitter.com/flowermoundband</a>                                                                                          |
| Band YouTube              | <a href="https://www.youtube.com/@OfficialFlowerMoundBand">@OfficialFlowerMoundBand</a>                                                                                |
| Guard Instagram           | <a href="https://www.instagram.com/flomoguard">@flomoguard</a>                                                                                                         |
| Guard site                | <a href="https://flomocg.com">flomocg.com</a>                                                                                                                          |
| FloMo Guard Parents group | The guard parent side: polls, anonymous questions, @everyone tags, real answers. Running since 2012.                                                                   |
| FloMo Band Parents group  | The band-wide parent group: 1.4K members, about 116 posts a month, running since 2012. Joining requires being in the Presto database, so register with the band first. |

## Winter guard season adds these

| Platform           | What you will use it for                                                                                                  |
|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| NTCA               | North Texas circuit schedules, results, and the FMHS group page                                                           |
| WGI                | National circuit events, scores, and Dayton in April                                                                      |
| FloMarching        | Streams WGI, same subscription as fall                                                                                    |
| CompetitionSuite * | Where guard scores and judge recaps often post, ask the guard staff if parents get access                                 |
| Designs by King    | Where guard parents source practice rifles for home spinning. Yes, your living room is about to become a rehearsal space. |

## The student layer, theirs not yours

| App                               | What it does                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ultimate Drill Book *             | Their drill and dots, on their phone. When they stare at their screen at dinner, this might actually be homework. |
| Tonal Energy *                    | The tuner and metronome app every Texas band kid has. The smiley face means they are in tune.                     |
| GroupMe / Discord section chats * | Where real information travels 20 minutes before any official channel. You will never see it. Make peace.         |

## The honest summary

Call it fifteen platforms, and none of them talk to each other. This is normal. Set up the must-haves in week one, follow the socials, join the parent groups, and remember the split: Presto and BAND carry the official word, the Facebook groups carry the parent word, and the truth usually needs both. When all else fails, [president@fmhsband.org](mailto:president@fmhsband.org) reaches an actual human.

## Sources

- FMHS Band Boosters page, the master link list
- FMHS Band FAQ
- LISD athletics tickets
- LISD Skyward
- LISD Rank One portal
- FloMo Guard Parents Facebook group, three seasons of posts, 2023 through 2025

Checked August 2026. Programs change platforms without warning, usually in July.

# Common Questions, Blunt Answers

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*Clarifications for new Texas band and guard parents*

Questions we asked, heard asked, or watched get asked in the group chat at 11 p.m. Answers are short on purpose. Long versions live in the starter guide.

## Getting in

**Does my kid need band experience to join color guard?** No. Guard auditions are movement based. Dance and gymnastics kids convert fast, orchestra kids too. Ours went from orchestra to the weapon line.

**We missed spring auditions. Is it over?** Ask anyway. Programs find spots for motivated kids more often than the posted process suggests.

**What are all these levels?** Big programs run a JV and varsity marching band and multiple guard levels, placed by audition. Placement is about ability today, not politics. Kids move up.

**My kid is shy and knows nobody.** Band eats that problem in about two weeks. Sections adopt their freshmen.

## Money

**What does the fee actually cover?** Usually meals, show shirts, entries, instruction. Usually not shoes, gloves, lessons, trips, merch, or the tea stops.

**Can we pay in installments?** Yes. Payment plans are standard. Ask.

**We can't afford it.** Email the director, one line: "we need some help this season." Quiet scholarship processes exist everywhere and they have done it a hundred times. Nobody announces it, nobody judges it.

**Are the fundraisers worth it?** Yes. The mulch sale (or whatever yours sells) is real money, and some programs credit your kid's account for what they sell.

## Time and camp

**Can we take a vacation during band camp?** No. The calendar comes out months early, plan around it. Miss camp and someone else learns your kid's dot.

**Why is rehearsal running late again?** Because posted end times are a suggestion. 20 to 30 minutes over is standard everywhere. Arriving 15 early, though, that one is enforced.

**When does it calm down?** Fourth Monday of August the 8-hour rule kicks in, then it settles: a couple rehearsals a week, Friday game, some Saturdays.

**Is my kid too tired?** Probably yes, probably fine. Watch grades and injuries, not tired. Tired is the product. Somehow 500 exhausted kids still put up clean runs every Saturday.

**Can they do band and a sport, or theater, or a job?** School sports, yes: the handbook says directors and coaches work out conflicts when both sides give a little, and kids do it every year. The fine print that surprises people: CLUB sports and other non-school activities are not excused absences. Neither are club meetings, tutorials, or family outings. Illness and family emergencies are.

**What if my kid wants to quit mid-year?** Big one, and the policy has teeth: LISD defines band as a full-year commitment, and a student who leaves mid-year sits out a FULL year before returning to the program. So before any October quitting conversation, know that most October misery is fatigue, not fit, and a talk with the directors comes first. The decision point is spring course selection, not the hard week.

**We have a wedding on a band Friday. Now what?** Absence requests go through the band website form, in advance: 24 hours notice for a rehearsal, two full weeks for a performance. Approval is at the directors' discretion. Unexcused rehearsal absences can cost the halftime performance that week, and unexcused camp absences can move a kid to the Jaguar Band. Ask early, in writing, always.

**How is band graded?** Four equal parts per nine weeks: pass-offs (playing checkoffs on assigned music), attendance, daily rehearsal etiquette, and performances as major grades. Translation: show up, behave, learn your part, play the shows, and the grade takes care of itself.

## Games and contests

**Do I buy tickets to watch my own kid?** Yes. Football through the district ticket system, UIL State through Ticketmaster, BOA online or at the gate. Budget for it.

**When do they actually perform at a football game?** Halftime, plus stand tunes all night. They stay the whole game and get home near midnight.

**What is the difference between UIL and BOA?** UIL is the school league, everyone does it, ends at the Alamodome. BOA is the national circuit some bands add, also ends at the Alamodome, different weekend. Same field, different scoreboards.

**What does prelims and finals mean for my Saturday?** They perform in the morning, everyone waits all day, they perform again at night if they advance. Seat cushion, sunscreen, book.

**Can I see my kid at a contest?** For about 10 minutes while they walk to the bus, if you position yourself well. This is normal and nobody warns you.

**What happens if football makes the playoffs?** The season stretches. Friday commitments can run deep toward December, the band goes where the team goes.

## Guard

**Is guard part of the band or separate?** Fall: part of the band, scored inside the band's score, same buses. Winter: its own indoor season (NTCA locally, WGI nationally) with its own fee.

**What is a weapon?** Rifle and sabre. Wood and plastic, nothing fires, everything gets thrown. It is the advanced equipment, and making the weapon line is a big deal.

**Why does my guard kid have practice before band camp even starts?** UIL lets guard learn show choreography earlier in the summer than the wind players. Legal, normal, everywhere.

**What is this second fee in November?** Winter guard. Separate season, separate costume, separate travel. If the guard is good, quietly budget for Dayton in April too.

## School and grades

**Does marching band count for PE credit?** In Texas, yes, the fall marching semester substitutes for PE credit within state limits. The counselor squares it at schedule time, worth confirming.

**Does No Pass No Play apply to band?** Yes. Fail a class at a grading period and your kid sits out performances and contests until grades recover under the state rules. Directors run tight ships about grades for exactly this reason.

**A physical, really?** Really. Entering 9th and 11th grade, plus any 7th or 8th grade marcher, on the UIL form, and a medical history form signed every year. A June appointment beats an August panic.

## Myths that need killing

- “State only happens for our class every other year.” Old news. Every classification goes to the Alamodome every year now.
- “The 8-hour rule means only 8 hours of band.” Rehearsal is capped. Games, contests, and performance days sit outside the cap.
- “Guard is a side thing.” Guard is scored with the band and can decide contests.
- “Band is a fall activity.” Band is a school-year activity: marching in fall, concert season and UIL evaluations in spring, winter guard and winter percussion in between.
- “The fee is the whole cost.” The fee is the floor, not the ceiling.
- “Communication will be organized because the program is elite.” The show will be flawless and the pickup time will still be wrong in three different apps. Unrelated skills.

## Sources

- UIL marching band rules and FAQ

- TEA physical education FAQ, PE substitution
- UIL and TEA eligibility side by side
- UIL State tickets on Ticketmaster

Checked August 2026. District rules vary at the edges. Your director's email wins ties.

# The WISK Digest, 2026-27 Season

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*The FMHS Band's weekly WISK emails, condensed and organized for quick reference. Newest week first.*

The WISK (What I Should Know) is the Flower Mound Band's official weekly email, sent through Presto Assistant on Sunday evenings. Each issue below is boiled down to actions, dates, and news. Contact emails appear exactly as the band publishes them. Passwords and discount codes are the one thing left off this public page, since it can be found by anyone on the internet. Those live in the WISK itself and in Presto.

## Current action items, as of August 17

| Do this                                                                       | Deadline                  | Where                                                                                                                             |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Order band photos with the early discount                                     | Aug 17, 11:59pm           | Order link and code in the WISK                                                                                                   |
| Away Game Meal Form, required for every student                               | Aug 21                    | Link in the WISK, questions to Kerry Mays and Mary Bowman at <a href="mailto:activities@fmhsband.org">activities@fmhsband.org</a> |
| Dietary Restriction Form, required for every student                          | Aug 21                    | Link in the WISK                                                                                                                  |
| VOLY volunteer background check, required before helping at any band activity | ASAP, takes up to 2 weeks | LISD VOLY portal                                                                                                                  |
| Confirm or decline white marching shoes on the reply form                     | ASAP                      | Form in the WISK, size exchanges to <a href="mailto:shoes@fmhsband.org">shoes@fmhsband.org</a>                                    |
| Drumline jacket order, \$100, optional                                        | Aug 17                    | Drumline liaison Julie Riekse, personal email in the WISK                                                                         |

## Season dates pulled from the WISKS so far

| Date       | What                                                                                                                          |
|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Mon Aug 17 | Band photos, 5pm to 8pm, football uniform, no makeup day                                                                      |
| Mon Aug 24 | Booster meeting, 7pm                                                                                                          |
| Thu Aug 27 | First football game, FM vs McKinney Boyd, away. McKinney ISD Stadium, 4201 S. Hardin Blvd, McKinney. Tickets, 7:30pm kickoff. |
| Mon Aug 31 | Midwest Clinic photo shoot, Wind Symphony                                                                                     |
| Thu Sep 3  | FM vs Timber Creek, away. KISD Athletics Complex, 500 Pate-Orr Rd N, Keller. Tickets on Brushfire, 7pm kickoff.               |
| Sat Sep 5  | March-a-Thon, 9am to 3pm                                                                                                      |
| Fri Feb 20 | Second drumline recycling fundraiser, student run                                                                             |

Full game-day logistics for every 2026 football game, addresses and ticket links included, live on the Calendars page.

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## Week of August 17, sent Aug 16

### Actions

- Band photos Monday, August 17. Report to the Auditorium at 5pm in football uniform, long white socks if band shoes have not arrived. Over 400 students, runs until 8pm, and there is no makeup day. If you want an individual photo, tell your kid to stay for it.
- Away Game Meal and Dietary Restriction forms due August 21, required for every student whether or not you buy meals. Kids go straight from dismissal to inspection before away games, so there is no time to eat at home.
- VOLY: LISD requires an annual background check before helping at any band activity. It takes up to two weeks and does not obligate you to anything. File it now so October-you can say yes to things.

- White marching shoes for everyone this year. Confirm or decline on the reply form, check the fit when they arrive, exchanges via shoes@fmhsband.org.
- Wind Symphony concert uniform fitting needs volunteer hands, signup in the WISK, prepping for Midwest Clinic photos.
- Drumline jackets, \$100 and optional, orders close August 17 through drumline liaison Julie Riekse (“Rick-see”), personal email in the WISK.

#### News

- First Parent Preview is in the books and both marching bands are off to a strong start.
- The drumline recycling fundraiser raised \$3,141 in electronics and household goods. Round two lands February 20 and the students run it.

### Week of August 10, sent Aug 9

#### Actions

- Meal and dietary forms opened, due August 21.
- Band photo orders open with the early discount, code in the WISK.
- Watch for a text from the merch team when orders are ready. Pop-up store at Parent Preview on August 15.

#### News

- This week ran on parents: uniform issue, fruit break, dinners, and prop building. It takes a village and ours is one of the best, per the directors.
- Fall band classes go outside during the school day. Full water cooler and athletic clothes, every day.
- The SmugMug 2026-27 gallery is live, password in the WISK. The photography team uploads constantly, start saving favorites for memory book season now.
- Memory Book student team applications open for students who want to help build it.

### Week of August 3, sent Aug 2

#### Actions

- Makeup registration Thursday, 6pm, Main Campus Cafeteria. Complete the online portion first, password in the WISK.
- Band picture orders opened, early discount code in the WISK.

#### News

- Cluster Pep Rally August 4 in the Arena: all brass, woodwinds, and battery, navy swoosh shirts.
- Parents are welcome at rehearsal anytime, with two rules: do not wave at your kid, and stay clear of the performance space including the front ensemble.
- DCI Watch Party August 8, all members, FMHS Auditorium.
- First day of school August 12. Meet the Jags community pep rally August 13. First Parent Preview August 15 at 7pm.

### Week of July 27, sent Jul 26

#### Actions

- New physical required for every student for the 2026 season, due before camp began July 28, uploaded through the band’s form. Questions to Mr. Willard at willardt@lisd.net.
- Subscribe to the band calendar at fmhsband.org, password in the WISK. Everyone subscribes to General, then add your kid’s groups.

#### News

- Summer band opened Tuesday, July 28: mornings 7:30 to 11:30 for all members, afternoon sectionals, and an evening block for Competition Band hopefuls, six days a week.
- Competition Band placement results posted in Canvas after the Wednesday evening rehearsal.
- FM9 freshmen attended orientation July 29, second session, dismissed from rehearsal at 9:30am to make it.

- Fruit Break: every section brings assigned fruit on its assigned day and volunteers cut and bag it for morning break. Guard brings the apples on Saturday.
  - Camp survival, straight from the directors: half gallon cooler minimum, light colored clothing, athletic shoes, hat, sunglasses, sunscreen, and a protein breakfast.
- 

## **How this page works**

Each week's WISK gets condensed here after it lands on Sunday. The full text lives in your email and Presto. If anything here disagrees with the WISK, the WISK wins, then open an issue so it gets fixed.



# Calendars

Every FMHS band calendar, how to get them on your phone, and where every football game actually is.

## The three band calendars

The band publishes its schedule as public Google Calendars: a General calendar everyone follows, plus group calendars you add depending on where your student landed. The WISK and the band website identify which is which. Subscribe to General plus your student's groups.

| Calendar            | View in browser | Subscribe address (Google)                           | ICS link (iPhone and Outlook) |
|---------------------|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Band calendar one   | open            | 84jp7ctks4behcmpes3ocdb1n4@group.calendar.google.com | ICS                           |
| Band calendar two   | open            | nulalp5qm4fjm4nq8bhe5df0@group.calendar.google.com   | ICS                           |
| Band calendar three | open            | 1m5pjqaes2pd3g5b68l9hhpuig@group.calendar.google.com | ICS                           |

## Put them on your phone

### iPhone, Apple Calendar

1. Settings, then Calendar, then Accounts. On newer iOS it is Settings, then Apps, then Calendar, then Calendar Accounts.
2. Add Account, then Other, then Add Subscribed Calendar.
3. Paste an ICS link from the table, tap Next, tap Save.
4. Repeat for each calendar you want. Done, it updates itself forever.

### Android, Google Calendar

1. Open calendar.google.com in a browser. Desktop mode is easiest.
2. On the left, find Other calendars and tap the plus sign.
3. Choose Subscribe to calendar and paste the subscribe address from the table.
4. It shows up in the Google Calendar app on its own. If it hides, open the app settings, find the calendar, and turn on sync and visibility.

### Outlook

1. Open the Outlook calendar, choose Add calendar, then Subscribe from web.
2. Paste an ICS link, name it something like FM Band, and add it.
3. Classic desktop Outlook: File, Account Settings, Internet Calendars tab, New, paste the ICS link.

These links work because the band publishes the calendars publicly. If one ever demands a login, the band changed a setting, check the WISK for the current instructions.

## Football 2026, where you are actually driving

The kids ride buses. You do not. Every game, with the stadium, the address, and where tickets live. Buy ahead online, most DFW districts are cashless at the gate and run clear bag policies, so check the host district's site before you drive.

| Date               | Opponent      | Home or away | Stadium and address                                       | Tickets                 |
|--------------------|---------------|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| Thu Aug 27, 7:30pm | McKinney Boyd | Away         | McKinney ISD Stadium, 4201 S. Hardin Blvd, McKinney 75070 | McKinney ISD box office |
| Thu Sep 3, 7:00pm  | Timber Creek  | Away         | KISD Athletics Complex, 500 Pate-Orr Rd N, Keller 76248   | Keller ISD on Brushfire |

| Date               | Opponent   | Home or away | Stadium and address                                                        | Tickets                                    |
|--------------------|------------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Fri Sep 11, 7:00pm | Boswell    | Home         | Neal E. Wilson Stadium at FMHS, 3411 Peters Colony Rd, Flower Mound 75022  | LISD box office                            |
| Fri Sep 25, 7:00pm | Braswell   | Home         | Neal E. Wilson Stadium at FMHS                                             | LISD box office                            |
| Fri Oct 2, 7:00pm  | Little Elm | Away         | Lobo Stadium, 400 Lobo Lane, Little Elm 75068                              | Little Elm ticketing                       |
| Fri Oct 9, 7:00pm  | Marcus     | Home         | Neal E. Wilson Stadium at FMHS. The crosstown game. Arrive absurdly early. | LISD box office                            |
| Fri Oct 16, 7:00pm | Wakeland   | Away         | Frisco ISD venue, announced on the schedule since FISD rotates stadiums    | Frisco ISD box office                      |
| Fri Oct 23, 7:00pm | Lewisville | Home         | Neal E. Wilson Stadium at FMHS                                             | LISD box office                            |
| Fri Oct 30, 7:00pm | Hebron     | Away         | Brian Brazil Stadium at Hebron HS, 4207 Plano Pkwy, Carrollton 75010       | LISD box office, same system as home games |
| Thu Nov 5, 7:00pm  | Guyer      | Home         | Neal E. Wilson Stadium at FMHS                                             | LISD box office                            |

Away game notes:

- The Hebron trip is the easy one: LISD school, same ticket system, short drive.
- Three Thursday games this year (Aug 27, Sep 3, Nov 5). School night, kid home late, first period anyway.
- Playoffs run past November 5 at neutral sites announced week by week. The band goes where the team goes.

## Band season anchors

From the WISKs and public contest schedules. The Google calendars above are the source of truth for the fine grain.

| When                    | What                                                                                             |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sat Sep 5               | March-a-Thon, 9am to 3pm                                                                         |
| Sep and Oct Saturdays   | Contest season. Watch the WISK for the band's specific entries.                                  |
| Fri Nov 6 and Sat Nov 7 | BOA San Antonio Super Regional, Alamodome                                                        |
| Mon Nov 9 to Wed Nov 11 | UIL 6A State Marching Band Championship, Alamodome, if the band advances through Region and Area |
| December                | Midwest Clinic, Chicago. Wind Symphony performs at band's most prestigious stage.                |
| Fri Feb 20              | Drumline recycling fundraiser, round two, student run                                            |

## Sources

- MaxPreps, FMHS 2026 football schedule
- McKinney ISD Stadium info
- Keller ISD football tickets and KISD Athletics Complex
- Little Elm Lobo Stadium
- LISD athletics tickets
- BOA 2026 schedule and UIL State Marching

Checked August 2026. Kickoff times move, venues occasionally shuffle, the host district's site wins ties.

# The Band Dictionary

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Every word the WISK assumes you already know. Plain definitions, FloMo flavor included.

The starter guide has the ten-word survival glossary. This is the full decoder ring: skim it once in August and suddenly the emails make sense.

## People you will hear about

| Term                 | What it means                                                                                                                                                           |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Directors            | The faculty. They run the program, teach the classes, and answer the hard questions.                                                                                    |
| Techs / staff        | Hired specialists who coach one thing: brass tech, guard tech, percussion tech. Not faculty, absolutely part of the machine.                                            |
| Clinician            | An outside expert brought in to sharpen the show. When an unfamiliar name shows up on the calendar next to a stadium rehearsal, that's a clinician day, and it matters. |
| Mr. Spaeth           | FloMo's recurring example of the above. When the WISK says "Mr. Spaeth here," expect long stadium nights and a noticeably better show afterward.                        |
| Drum major           | The student conductor on the podium. There are usually several. Yes, it's a huge honor.                                                                                 |
| Section leader       | The student in charge of one instrument's crew. Your kid's first boss.                                                                                                  |
| Liaison              | The parent volunteer who owns one slice of the program: drumline liaison, guard liaison. They know everything about their slice.                                        |
| Boosters / the board | The parent nonprofit that funds and staffs everything the district doesn't. Budget like a small company, salary of zero.                                                |

## The ensembles, decoded for FMHS

| Term                              | What it means                                                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Competition Band                  | The varsity marching band, around 200 members, the one at contests. Placement announced after evening rehearsals in week one (results post in Canvas). |
| Jaguar Band                       | The JV marching band. Same music, lighter travel, own rehearsal track.                                                                                 |
| Wind Symphony                     | The top concert band. This is the group performing at Midwest Clinic.                                                                                  |
| Symphonic, Concert, Varsity bands | The rest of the concert band ladder, by audition, spring semester's main event.                                                                        |
| Battery                           | The drumline that marches: snares, tenors, basses.                                                                                                     |
| Pit / front ensemble              | The percussion parked at the front sideline: marimbas, vibes, synths, the big toys. They don't march, they haul.                                       |
| Color guard                       | Flags, rifles, sabres, dance. Scored inside the band's score in fall, own circuit in winter.                                                           |
| Weapon line                       | The guard members who spin rifle and sabre. Advanced equipment, big deal, congratulate accordingly.                                                    |
| Winter guard                      | Guard's own indoor competitive season, roughly December through April, NTCA locally and WGI nationally. Separate fee, separate calendar.               |
| Winter percussion                 | Same idea for the drumline, indoor season in the spring semester.                                                                                      |

## Events that will appear on your calendar

| Term                    | What it means                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Summer band / band camp | The late-July-through-August grind that builds the show. See the starter guide for survival.                                                                                                          |
| Sectionals              | Rehearsal for just one instrument group. Usually the afternoon block.                                                                                                                                 |
| Masterclass             | A visiting expert teaches one section during class time (woodwind masterclass, brass masterclass, dance masterclass). Free coaching from serious players.                                             |
| Stadium rehearsal       | Evening full-band rehearsal in the actual stadium, usually 6 to 9pm. The show gets real here.                                                                                                         |
| Run-through / full run  | Performing the whole show top to bottom without stopping. What everything else builds toward.                                                                                                         |
| Pass-offs               | Graded playing checkoffs on assigned music, tracked on a sheet each nine weeks. A quarter of the band grade.                                                                                          |
| Challenge               | The process for a Jaguar Band member to evaluate into the Competition Band on marching and playing skills. The door is always open.                                                                   |
| The itinerary           | The minute-by-minute schedule for the week, distributed every Monday during marching season. The WISK's more detailed sibling.                                                                        |
| Parent Preview          | The first public performance of the show, parents invited, usually mid-August. Bring tissues, it sneaks up on you.                                                                                    |
| March-a-Thon            | All-day fundraiser where the band marches and plays around town collecting donations. FloMo's is early September, 9am to 3pm.                                                                         |
| Meet the Jags           | FMHS's community pep rally in week one of school. All members perform.                                                                                                                                |
| Cluster pep rally       | A rally for the FMHS feeder-school family (the "cluster"). Band plays, younger kids get recruited by osmosis.                                                                                         |
| FM9                     | The ninth grade campus. Freshman band members split time between FM9 events and the main campus program.                                                                                              |
| DCI watch party         | The band gathers to watch Drum Corps International finals on a big screen. DCI is the professional-adjacent summer marching circuit, and it's where half the staff's ideas come from.                 |
| Inspection              | The pre-departure check before games and contests: uniform complete, instrument ready, kid presentable. Miss inspection, miss the bus.                                                                |
| Prelims / finals        | Contest format: perform in the morning, wait, perform again at night if you advance.                                                                                                                  |
| Region, Area, State     | The UIL playoff ladder. Region in October, Area next, State at the Alamodome in November.                                                                                                             |
| Midwest Clinic          | The band world's biggest conference, held in Chicago every December. Being invited to perform is a national-level honor for a concert band. FMHS Wind Symphony is going. Yes, that's a very big deal. |

## Gear your kid will suddenly own

| Term             | What it means                                                                                                    |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dot              | Your kid's exact coordinate on the field for one moment of the show.                                             |
| Drill / sets     | The full choreography, learned as numbered pages of dots.                                                        |
| Dot book         | The little notebook (or app) with every dot in it. Losing it is a genuine crisis.                                |
| Football uniform | The game-night marching uniform, issued at registration. Worn for band photos too.                               |
| Bibbers          | The overall-style uniform pants under the jacket.                                                                |
| Shako and plume  | The tall uniform hat and the feather that rides in it. The plume box is sacred, do not touch.                    |
| Gauntlets        | The wrist pieces. Perpetually almost lost.                                                                       |
| Swoosh shirt     | FMHS's navy spirit shirt, the default "look uniform without the uniform" outfit for pep rallies and appearances. |
| Show shirt       | The annual t-shirt themed to this year's show. Wear it to contests, wash it Thursday nights.                     |

| Term               | What it means                                                                                                         |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dinkles            | Band shoes, technically a brand name that went generic. FMHS is in white shoes this year, hence the shoe forms.       |
| Flag, rifle, sabre | Guard equipment, in ascending order of “gets thrown terrifyingly high.” The rifle is wood and plastic, nothing fires. |
| Props              | The scenery the band hauls on and off the field. Built, moved, and repaired by parent volunteers.                     |
| The trailer        | The semi or box truck that moves instruments and props. Watching it get packed is watching a religion.                |
| Stand tunes        | The short songs the band plays in the bleachers all game. You will have all of them memorized by October.             |

## Alphabet soup

| Term | What it means                                                                                                                                                  |
|------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| UIL  | University Interscholastic League, the Texas school activities league. Runs the Region, Area, State marching ladder, concert evaluations, and the 8-hour rule. |
| BOA  | Bands of America, the national contest circuit. Regionals across Texas, San Antonio Super Regional at the Alamodome, Grand Nationals in Indianapolis.          |
| WGI  | Winter Guard International, the national winter guard and percussion circuit. Season ends in Dayton, Ohio every April.                                         |
| NTCA | North Texas Colorguard Association, the DFW winter guard circuit where FloMo guards compete locally.                                                           |
| TCGC | Texas Color Guard Circuit, the equivalent circuit for much of the rest of Texas.                                                                               |
| DCI  | Drum Corps International, the elite summer marching circuit for age 16 to 22 performers. The big leagues your kid’s techs probably marched in.                 |
| WISK | What I Should Know, the band’s Sunday email through Presto. The official word. Condensed weekly in the digest.                                                 |
| VOLY | LISD’s volunteer portal. Annual background check, two weeks to clear, required before you can help.                                                            |

## FloMo traditions you will encounter

| Term                      | What it means                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| AMA                       | Ask Me Anything: summer Thursdays, board members in the band parking lot for the last hour of practice, answering any question. The officially sanctioned place to feel new. |
| Fruit break               | During camp, each section brings assigned fruit on its assigned day and volunteers cut and serve it at morning break. Guard brings the apples on Saturday.                   |
| The WISK’s 3-week outlook | The rolling calendar at the bottom of every WISK. Read it before scheduling anything, including dentist appointments and weddings.                                           |
| Boo Buckets               | A guard parent tradition: treat buckets for the kids around Halloween, funded by parent Venmo chip-ins.                                                                      |
| Memory book               | The end-of-year photo book built from the season’s SmugMug galleries, with a student team helping collect shots.                                                             |
| Events named after food   | Booster feed-the-band operations rotate through the season. If a food-named event appears in the WISK, volunteers and crockpots are about to be requested.                   |

Missing a word? Open an issue, or ask the nearest veteran parent, who will answer in three more words you don’t know yet.

# Contest Day Survival

---

*Your first marching contest Saturday, parking lot to midnight*

The band leaves before you wake up, performs for about eight minutes total, and gets home near midnight. Somehow this becomes your favorite day of the fall. Here is the whole day in order, so nothing surprises you but the show.

## The two flavors of Saturday

|               | UIL                                                                                                                      | BOA                                                                 |
|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| What it is    | The school league. Region, then Area, then State.                                                                        | The national circuit. Regionals, Super Regionals, Grand Nationals.  |
| How it scores | Region is ratings: earn a Division I and rank high enough to advance. Area is a ranked knockout. State is the Alamodome. | Ranked placements plus captions, prelims and finals at every event. |
| The vibe      | Every band in the region, one day, business-like                                                                         | Bigger productions, longer days, louder crowds                      |
| Tickets       | Gate admission, host sets the price                                                                                      | Real ticket prices, buy ahead for Super Regionals                   |

Flower Mound runs both worlds, and the November stack is real: BOA San Antonio Super Regional November 6 and 7, then UIL 6A State November 9 to 11, same building, back to back weeks. Book San Antonio hotels absurdly early.

## The shape of the day

1. Your kid leaves early, on the bus, in uniform or hauling it. You are not driving them. Feed them before they go.
2. You leave later, tickets already bought on your phone, and park where the signs say, not where hope says.
3. Prelims: the band performs once in the morning or early afternoon. Eight minutes. Do not be in line for nachos.
4. The wait: hours. The band eats, changes, naps in a gym somewhere. You watch other bands, which is secretly great.
5. Finals announcement: if the band advances, everyone stays. Nobody is going home early. Nobody.
6. Finals at night, under lights, better than prelims every single time.
7. Retreat: all the bands on the field for awards. Scores read from the bottom up. Cardiac event optional.
8. Buses home. Kid walks off the bus at some unholy hour, sunburned and hoarse and happy.

## What to bring

- Stadium seat or cushion. Metal bleachers, ten hours. Do the math.
- Sunscreen and a hat for the day, a layer for the night. Texas does both in one Saturday.
- Phone charger or battery pack. You will film everything.
- Clear bag, because most stadiums enforce it now.
- Cash is mostly useless, gates and concessions run cashless. Cards and phones.
- Binoculars if you like watching your specific kid instead of the show. No judgment.

## Where to sit and how to act

- Sit high, between the 30 yard lines. The show is designed to be read from up there. Front row is for hearing brass and seeing ankles.
- Do not walk in or out while any band performs. Move during the gaps. Ushers at BOA will hold you at the tunnel anyway.
- Clap for every band. Someone's exhausted kid is on that field too.
- When your band takes the field, you may scream. This is Texas. It's expected.

## **Following from home**

Can't make it? FloMarching streams BOA and WGI events on a subscription. UIL posts results on uiltexas.org, BOA posts on musicforall.org, and the parent Facebook groups will beat both of them by twenty minutes.

## **The ten minutes you get**

You will see your kid for about ten minutes, somewhere between the buses and the gate, if you position yourself well. Bring them food they can hold in one hand. Tell them they were great. They were. Then they disappear back into the machine, and you drive home alone listening to the recording you just made.

## **Want the good seats? Join the crew**

Props and pit crew parents go ON the field. They push the marimbas, set the props, and stand in the end zone while the show happens twenty feet away. It is the best view in the stadium and it costs eight hours of sweat. Cheap. Sign up through the volunteer channels, VOLY background check first.

## **After**

Scores post late and the internet has opinions. Skip that. Whatever the placement, the kid in your car is exhausted and proud, and the only correct postgame analysis is food. Analysis never, tacos always.

## **Sources**

- UIL marching band advancement procedures
- UIL State Marching Band Contest
- BOA 2026 schedule

Checked August 2026.

# The Money Guide

---

*What band actually costs, and how families actually pay for it*

Nobody hides the band fee. Everything else arrives one surprise at a time. This is the whole map, with Flower Mound's real numbers where we have them.

## The bill you can see

The FMHS band fee for 2026-27 is **\$700, with a \$250 deposit**, collected through JotForm at registration. It covers roughly what fees cover everywhere: game and contest meals, show shirts, entry fees, and the small army of instructors. Guard fees run their own track with costuming in the mix.

Payment plans are standard, spread across the fall. Nobody at the table blinks at installments. They blink at surprises, so get the deposit in on time.

## The bills you cannot see yet

| Item                              | Ballpark                              | Notes                                                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Marching shoes                    | \$30 to \$60                          | White this year at FMHS, confirm or decline on the shoe form                                                                |
| Gloves, socks, under-uniform gear | \$20 to \$40                          | Sections specify, kids lose gloves like it's a sport                                                                        |
| School instrument fee             | \$100 a year                          | For school-owned horns, separate check to FMHS Band, covers routine maintenance. Damage beyond normal use bills separately. |
| Reeds, oil, sticks, heads         | \$10 to \$30 a month                  | Woodwind parents know the reed economy is a racket                                                                          |
| Private lessons                   | \$24 per half hour, \$48 per hour     | Handbook rates. Strongly encouraged, and need-based lesson scholarships exist: meet privately with Mr. Biskup.              |
| Solo and Ensemble                 | entry fee plus accompanist fee        | Early March, required for winds and percussion, the accompanist covers two rehearsals and the performance                   |
| Uniform replacement, if lost      | jacket \$240, pants \$133, shako \$60 | Guard the garment bag (\$12) like jewelry. Hangers are \$5 and somehow always missing.                                      |
| Away game meals                   | set by the program                    | Buy through the meal form or send food, the form is required either way                                                     |
| Merch                             | whatever you allow                    | The Square store is good and it knows it                                                                                    |
| Tea stops and spending money      | \$10 to \$20 a week                   | The reloadable card from the starter guide earns its keep                                                                   |
| Contest tickets for you           | \$10 to \$40 per person per event     | Football gates plus UIL and BOA admission adds up across a fall                                                             |
| FloMarching subscription          | about \$30 a month in season          | Only if you want streams of the events you miss                                                                             |

## The seasonal spikes

- **Winter guard and winter percussion:** separate seasons, separate fees, costume included. If your kid's guard makes the WGI trip, add travel to Dayton in April.
- **Trip years:** when the band travels big (a bowl game, a parade, a far contest), add \$500 to \$2,000, announced far ahead with its own payment plan.
- **Weapon kids who fly:** the long gun case with real locks, one-time, so the rifle can vacation with you.
- **Senior year:** banquet, memory book, senior night flowers, and every "last one" you didn't budget tears for.



## How families actually cover it

- **Payment plans:** standard, monthly, ask at registration.
- **Fundraising with credits:** some fundraisers credit your student's account directly. Mulch sales, recycling drives (the drumline's last one raised \$3,141), March-a-Thon pledges. Treat them as tuition offsets, not bake sales.
- **The quiet path:** every big program has a discreet hardship process. One email to the directors, one sentence: "we need some help this season." It has been done a hundred times before you and nobody will ever know. A kid has never been marched out of a Texas band over money quietly asked about.
- **Booster donations are tax friendly:** the FMHS Band Boosters are a 501(c)(3), so direct donations may be deductible. Ask your tax person, not us.

## The honest total

For a wind player at FMHS in a normal year: fee plus gear plus tickets plus tea lands most families somewhere between \$1,000 and \$1,500 across the school year. Add winter guard and it climbs. Add a trip year and it climbs again. Compare it to a season of club sports and it suddenly looks reasonable, which is the most Texas sentence in this repo.

## Sources

- FMHS 2026-27 fee structure via the band's registration JotForm, reported in the parent groups
- Cypress Creek HS band fees, a comparable Texas program's public fee sheet
- FMHS Band Boosters, 501(c)(3) status per the sponsor page

Checked August 2026. Your fee sheet outranks this page.

# Winter Guard 101

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*The second season nobody warns band parents about*

Marching season ends in November and roughly two weeks later your guard kid has a new schedule, a new costume bill, and a competition season that runs to April. Welcome to winter guard. Nobody told us either.

## What it is

Indoor color guard: flags, rifles, sabres, and dance, performed on a folded-out vinyl floor in a gym, to recorded music, judged. No band, no field, no weather. It is guard distilled to itself, and it is where guard kids do their most serious work. WGI, the national body, calls it the Sport of the Arts, and for once marketing is accurate.

## How Flower Mound does it

Per the band handbook, FMHS fields two competitive winterguards: **World** and **National A**. Auditions run in the fall semester and are open to any FMHS student, marching experience or not. The guards compete locally in **NTCA** (North Texas Colorguard Association), the DFW circuit, with Saturday contests around the metroplex from roughly January into April, and in **WGI**, the national circuit, at regionals and, for the top guard, the World Championships in Dayton, Ohio, April 8 to 10, 2027.

## The classes, decoded

WGI and NTCA group guards by skill, not school size:

| Class      | Rough meaning                                                                                    |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Regional A | Developing groups, building fundamentals                                                         |
| A          | Solid, competitive, most school varsity guards live here                                         |
| Open       | Advanced, serious equipment work and staging                                                     |
| World      | The top of the sport. Nationally ranked groups, Dayton finals on ESPN-adjacent production values |

Kids move up classes as they improve, which means your freshman can realistically climb from JV to a world class floor by junior year. Ask us how we know.

## The calendar shape

- **Fall semester:** auditions and placements, open to any FMHS student, choreography begins as marching winds down
- **December and January:** rehearsals build, weeknights plus weekends, the show comes together
- **January through March:** NTCA Saturdays. Doors at 8am energy, your guard performs for about four minutes, awards at night if you stay
- **February and March:** WGI regionals for guards on that track, sometimes out of state
- **Early April:** NTCA Championships
- **April 8 to 10, 2027:** WGI World Championships, Dayton, for the guards that earn it. Book the hotel the day you find out.

Yes, that means you will drive two hours to watch four minutes. You have trained for this all fall.

## What it costs

A separate winter fee covering costume, floor, music licensing, travel entries, and instruction. Budget for gloves, shoes, tights, makeup kits, and hair supplies on top. If the guard flies to WGI events, add airfare and the long gun case with real locks for weapon kids, covered in the starter guide's travel section. Ask for winter numbers in October so November doesn't ambush you.

## The floor is a parent job

The vinyl competition floor gets rolled out, stretched, taped, and ripped back up in under two minutes of transition time at every show, and the people doing it are parents. Floor crew is winter's pit crew: sweaty, choreographed, and standing closer to the performance than any ticket can get you. Do it once and you're hooked.

## Show day rules

- **No flash photography, ever.** A flash during a rifle toss is genuinely dangerous. Venues announce it, believe them.
- Do not walk during a performance. Doors are held between groups.
- Shows run on tight schedules, check the circuit's posted times, arrive a group early.
- Scores post on the circuit's site and CompetitionSuite, and the guard parent group will have them faster.
- Clap for the tiny Regional A guard from a school you've never heard of. That was your kid two years ago.

## Why it's worth it

Fall belongs to the band. Winter belongs to the guard. The kids who spent marching season as one section of two hundred spend winter as the entire show, and the growth between December and April is visible to the naked eye. It is the best value in the marching arts, and the parking is easier.

## Sources

- WGI Sport of the Arts and future championship dates
- NTCA, North Texas Colorguard Association
- FMHS Color Guard and the FMHS NTCA group page

Checked August 2026.

# The Friday Night Guide

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*Football games, from call time to the midnight pickup lane*

Contests get the glory, but Friday nights are the actual job: ten of them this fall, some on Thursdays, every one ending with a kid climbing into your car past bedtime smelling like turf and brass. Here is how the night works.

## The kid's night

1. School ends. Home games: report to the band hall for call time. Away games: dismissal straight to inspection, then buses. There is no time to go home, which is why the meal form exists.
2. Inspection, in the Auditorium or Cafeteria, time listed on the weekly itinerary that comes out every Monday. Full uniform, tidy locker, instrument ready. The handbook's banned list is absolute: no makeup, no nail polish, no jewelry, no watches, long hair tied up and tucked in the hat. Fail inspection and you lose stands seating privileges. Per the handbook, the performance officially begins the moment they leave the inspection room and ends when they're back in the band hall after the game.
3. Pregame: the band marches in, plays the fight song and the anthem, sets the tone for the whole stadium.
4. First half: stand tunes, cheers, choreography with the student section, more playing than sitting. Assigned seats, full uniform, written parts only, and the handbook's finest sentence: "No spontaneous jam sessions."
5. Halftime: the show. Seven-ish minutes for which everyone did everything.
6. Third quarter: the traditional break. Kids get water and concessions and fifteen minutes of being teenagers.
7. Fourth quarter: back in the stands until the end. The band stays the whole game, always, both directions on the scoreboard.
8. Postgame: the band lines up on the track and returns to the band hall as a group, then unloads, then hangs the uniform correctly (the handbook is serious about this), then your car. Home games end near 11. Away games end past midnight. First period still exists tomorrow.

## Your night

- Buy tickets ahead on the district's system, home games through the LISD box office, away games through the host district (all ten games mapped with addresses and ticket links on the Calendars page).
- Clear bag, cashless concessions, the usual stadium rules.
- Sit where you can see the band, not just the field. Watching your kid do stand tunes for two hours is half the entertainment.
- At halftime, put the phone down for one run-through and just watch. Then film Saturday's, there will be plenty.
- Do not extract your kid mid-game to say hi. The band operates as a unit from call time to dismissal.
- Pickup: follow the band's posted pickup procedures, park where directed, and bring patience. Four hundred kids and one parking lot resolve at their own speed. A snack in the car makes you a legend.

## Nights that are different

- **Thursday games:** three this season (Aug 27, Sep 3, Nov 5). Same night, school night, plan the morning after with mercy.
- **Senior night:** the last home game. Seniors and their parents get announced on the field before the game. Flowers happen, tears happen, underclassman parents take notes because it arrives faster than advertised.
- **Homecoming:** louder, longer, more mums than physics should allow. The band plays through all of it.
- **Playoffs:** if football keeps winning, Fridays keep going into December, at neutral sites announced week by week. The band goes where the team goes, and nobody complains because playoff games are electric.
- **Weather:** games play through rain. Lightning forces delays, sometimes long ones, and the band shelters with everyone else. The night ends when it ends.

## The quiet truth

Friday nights are where band stops being an activity and becomes the social fabric of your kid's high school life. The stands are where the sections bond, the inside jokes are born, and the freshmen become people. You are just the ride home. It is a great job.

## Sources

- FMHS band pickup procedures and football season info
- 2026 schedule with venues and tickets, built from MaxPreps and district sites

Checked August 2026.

# All-Region 101

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*Why your kid is suddenly practicing scales at 6am, explained*

Sometime in September your kid starts disappearing into a practice room with three pieces of music called etudes, and nobody explains what's happening. This is what's happening.

## The short version

Texas runs an individual audition ladder alongside the band season, organized by TMEA (Texas Music Educators Association): **Region, then Area, then All-State**. Kids audition alone, behind a screen, judged blind, ranked against every player of their instrument in the region. The best make the Region band. The best of those advance toward the All-State bands, which perform at the TMEA convention in San Antonio in February. All-State is roughly the top 2 percent of auditioning musicians in the state, and Texas is the hardest state in the country to make it in.

## How the fall actually goes

| When                  | What                                                                                                                                                             |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Summer                | TMEA releases the audition etudes. The grind begins quietly.                                                                                                     |
| September and October | Private lessons and practice rooms fill with the same three excerpts on repeat. You will hear them in your sleep.                                                |
| Late November         | Region auditions, for FMHS that's <b>TMEA Region 24</b> . Blind, ranked. Ninth graders can audition for the 9th grade region band AND the upperclassmen bands.   |
| Late January          | Region Clinic and Concert: guest conductor, real repertoire, and per the handbook, earning a chair means the full clinic and concert are required, not optional. |
| Early January         | The top Region finishers become Area auditionees and travel with other LISD students <b>to Abilene</b> for Area auditions. Yes, Abilene. Pack accordingly.       |
| February              | Top Area finishers are named TMEA All-State and perform at the convention in San Antonio. Resume gold, memory platinum.                                          |

House rules at FMHS, from the handbook: Wind Symphony and Symphonic Band members are **required** to audition for Region. Concert and Varsity Band members are required to learn the music and do the graded pass-offs, and encouraged to audition. Nobody escapes the etudes entirely, which is the point.

## What it costs and what it takes

- A small audition entry fee, plus the region clinic fee if they make it.
- Private lessons are not required but the audition rooms are full of kids who take them. This is where that \$25 to \$40 a lesson earns its keep.
- No marching required: this is a pure playing contest. Quiet kids with good fundamentals thrive here.

## How to be useful

- Do not ask "did you win." Ask what chair, and then be impressed regardless, because auditioning alone behind a screen at 14 takes nerve most adults do not have.
- The etudes will sound repetitive and occasionally awful for weeks, and then one day they won't. That day is the whole process working.
- If they miss the cut: everyone misses the cut sometimes, the etudes change every year, and sophomores beat their freshman selves constantly. Food, not analysis. It works for auditions too.

## Solo and Ensemble, the spring sibling

The LISD Solo and Ensemble contest runs in **early March at FMHS**, and it's a ratings event, not a ranked one. The handbook makes it real: all wind and percussion students perform a solo AND a chamber ensemble. Solos should be in hand before winter break (suggested lists come home in late November),

chamber groups get assigned in December, and accompanied solos require an accompanist, which the band provides at a reasonable fee covering two rehearsals and the performance. Entry fees are on families, financial hardship gets one quiet email to a director, and once entered, finishing is required. It also feeds the lettering math directly: First Division ratings are worth real points.

## Sources

- TMEA All-State overview and audition process
- TMEA band audition material

Checked August 2026.

# The Volunteer Field Guide

*Every band parent job, decoded, so you can pick one on purpose*

Volunteering is not charity here, it is the only reliable way to see your kid between August and Thanksgiving, and the program physically does not run without it. But the jobs are wildly different, and nobody explains that before the signup links fly. Here is the menu.

**First, the prerequisite:** LISD requires an annual background check through the VOLY portal before you help with anything. It takes up to two weeks and commits you to nothing. File it before you need it.

## The jobs

| Job                 | What you actually do                                                                   | Time cost                               | Access level                                       | Best for                                                           |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Props and pit crew  | Push marimbas, carry props, build sets, sprint on and off the field during transitions | Every game and contest, plus build days | ON THE FIELD during the show. Best seats in Texas. | Strong backs, dads who miss being on a team                        |
| Uniforms            | Fittings, hemming, game-night checks, hanging 400 uniforms correctly                   | Big early-season push, then game nights | The band hall's inner sanctum, air conditioned     | Detail people, chatters, anyone who can thread a needle or fake it |
| Meals and feeding   | Away game meals, contest meals, fruit break during camp                                | Bursts around events                    | The cafeteria command center                       | Kitchen generals, Costco black belts                               |
| Chaperones          | Ride the buses, count heads, hold the medical bag, herd with love                      | Full game or contest days               | Everything the kids see, you see                   | Calm people, nurses, natural den parents                           |
| Hydration crew      | Water on the field at rehearsals and games                                             | Weekly, short shifts                    | Sideline adjacent                                  | Anyone with a truck and a hose reel                                |
| Photography team    | Shoot rehearsals and events, upload to SmugMug                                         | Flexible, self-directed                 | Field edge with a camera                           | Camera owners who were looking for an excuse                       |
| Merch table         | Sell at previews, games, and events                                                    | Event windows                           | The social crossroads of the program               | Retail veterans, people who like cash boxes                        |
| Floor crew (winter) | Roll, stretch, tape, and strike the winter guard floor in under two minutes            | Winter Saturdays                        | On the gym floor at every show                     | Guard parents, adrenaline enjoyers                                 |
| Committee and board | Budgets, contracts, fundraising, the machine behind the machine                        | Real hours, year round                  | How it all works                                   | Spreadsheet people, future presidents                              |

## How to start without overcommitting

1. Do the VOLY check now.
2. Pick ONE job for the fall. One. The program will happily absorb your whole life if you let it, and the veterans would rather have one reliable shift than five flaky ones.
3. Signups come through SignUpGenius links in the WISK and the parent Facebook groups. The good shifts go fast after each WISK lands on Sunday night.
4. Show up early once and you're family. The uniform moms remember everything.

## An honest ranking of the perks

1. **Pit crew:** you stand on the field during the show. Nothing else comes close.
2. **Chaperone:** you hear the bus culture, which is where band actually happens.
3. **Uniforms:** air conditioning and the best gossip.
4. **Meals:** 400 teenagers say thank you to you specifically.
5. **Floor crew:** winter's version of pit crew, plus you learn to move like a stagehand.



6. **Board:** no perks, just the quiet knowledge that none of it happens without you. Someone's got to, and the ones who do are the best of us.

## Sources

- LISD VOLY requirement, via the WISK
- FMHS Band Boosters

Checked August 2026.

# The Freshman Year Timeline

*The whole first year on one page, so nothing ambushes you*

Every month of a first band year at a program like Flower Mound's, with the FloMo anchors we know. Your dates will wobble by a week or two. The shape will not.

| Month            | What happens                                                                                                                                                                                         | What it costs you                                                         |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>July</b>      | Physicals uploaded, registration and deposit, band camp starts the last week. The gallon jug era begins.                                                                                             | Deposit, physical copay, camp gear, one emotional grocery run             |
| <b>August</b>    | Camp goes full days, school starts mid-month, Parent Preview, band photos, first game in week three. Forms cascade: meals, dietary, shoes, VOLY.                                                     | Fee installments, shoes, tickets, the first HTeaO of hundreds             |
| <b>September</b> | The rhythm locks in: weeknight rehearsals, Friday games, March-a-Thon, first contests. All-Region etudes quietly take over the practice room.                                                        | Game tickets, contest gas, pledge money                                   |
| <b>October</b>   | Peak season. Contests most Saturdays, UIL Region then Area, homecoming chaos, the show peaks. Sleep is a rumor.                                                                                      | Contest tickets, more gas, a stadium seat you wish you'd bought in August |
| <b>November</b>  | The summit: BOA San Antonio Super Regional, UIL State the next week, both at the Alamodome. Marching ends. Winter guard and percussion auditions. Concert band seating begins. All-Region auditions. | San Antonio hotel, State tickets, winter season deposit, audition fees    |
| <b>December</b>  | Winter ensembles start building. Holiday concert. Wind Symphony's Midwest Clinic trip. The first quiet Friday feels wrong.                                                                           | Concert attire if needed, winter fees begin                               |
| <b>January</b>   | Winter guard and percussion seasons open. Region band clinic and concert for the kids who made it. Area auditions for the ladder climbers.                                                           | Winter fees, region clinic fee, show entry days                           |
| <b>February</b>  | NTCA Saturdays roll, the drumline's recycling fundraiser returns Feb 20, All-Staters go to San Antonio.                                                                                              | Show tickets, TMEA trip if your kid made the top                          |
| <b>March</b>     | WGI regional season, spring break (actual family time, schedule nothing band-shaped), UIL Concert and Sight Reading prep.                                                                            | Regional travel if the guard flies                                        |
| <b>April</b>     | NTCA Championships, WGI Worlds in Dayton for the top guard (April 8 to 10, 2027), UIL Concert and Sight Reading evaluation.                                                                          | Dayton, if you're lucky enough to owe it                                  |
| <b>May</b>       | Spring concert, band banquet, awards, leadership and guard auditions for NEXT fall, and the show music for next season starts leaking.                                                               | Banquet tickets, flowers, tissues                                         |
| <b>June</b>      | The one real month off. Take the vacation now. This is not a suggestion.                                                                                                                             | Peace, briefly                                                            |

## The three biggest ambushes, flagged in advance

1. **November is two seasons colliding:** marching finals, winter auditions, and All-Region all stack into three weeks. Feed everyone, judge no one.
2. **Winter fees land right after fall fees end.** Ask for winter numbers in October so the November email is a confirmation, not a surprise.
3. **May auditions mean next year starts before this year ends.** The freshman year finish line is actually a lap marker. Nobody tells you that either, so we just did.

## Sources

- Dates assembled from the WISK Digest, the Calendars page, UIL, BOA, WGI, and TMEA

Checked August 2026.

# Winter Percussion 101

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*The drumline's second season, the loud sibling of winter guard*

If winter guard is guard distilled, winter percussion is the drumline unleashed: battery and front ensemble performing their own complete show on a gym floor, no band attached, judged in the same WGI universe as the guards. Same season, same gyms, more decibels.

## What it is

An indoor percussion ensemble builds a show the way the marching band does, with drill, staging, props, and a soundtrack the pit provides live. Groups compete in classes by skill level, from concert divisions (standstill, pure playing) to movement-based marching classes topping out at world class. The national circuit is **WGI Percussion**, whose championships run in Dayton every April, the week around the guard finals (dates at [wgi.org](http://wgi.org)). Texas groups also compete in state and local circuit shows through the winter, often sharing Saturday gyms with the winter guards.

## What it looks like at a big program

- Auditions land in late fall as marching season winds down, same window as winter guard.
- Rehearsals run weeknights and weekends, December through April.
- Show days are the same all-day gym Saturdays: warm up in a cafeteria, perform for about seven minutes, awards at night.
- The front ensemble hauls the same instruments as fall plus a full sound system. The equipment logistics are somehow bigger indoors than out.

Whether your program fields a full competitive indoor line every year, and in which circuit, varies by staffing and numbers. At FloMo, the drumline liaison and the WISK are the authority on what this winter holds. The fundraisers you saw in August (that \$3,141 recycling haul) are part of what pays for this season.

## What it costs

Same shape as winter guard: a separate winter fee covering the show, instruction, and entries, plus travel if the group hits WGI regionals out of town. Percussion adds equipment wear: heads, sticks, mallets have a season-long appetite. Budget like winter guard, add a sticks line.

## Parent jobs, indoor edition

The floor still gets rolled and taped by parents, and percussion adds the equipment push: racks, speakers, keyboards on carts, all moved into place during a timed transition while the previous group's parents move theirs out. It's a ballet performed by people in matching booster shirts. Sign up, you'll never watch a stage crew the same way again.

## Show day rules

Same as guard: no flash photography, no walking during performances, tight schedules, scores post fast. And the same secret: the small groups from small schools deserve your applause. Every world class line was one of them once.

## Why it matters

Fall makes drummers strong. Winter makes them musicians. The battery that spent October counting steps spends February phrasing, and the improvement compounds straight into next fall's marching show. If your kid lives in the drumline, winter is where they level up. Plan for the fee, enjoy the decibels.

## Sources

- WGI Percussion and future dates
- The WISK Digest for FloMo-specific winter plans as they're announced

Checked August 2026.

# The Grandma Page

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*How to love a band kid from a distance. Print this for the grandparents, aunts, uncles, and godparents.*

Your grandkid joined marching band, and this page exists because the questions are always the same: what is it, when can I see it, and why are they never free on Saturdays. Short answers below, written with love.

## What marching band is now

Not the halftime band you remember. Modern competitive marching band is a 7 to 8 minute theatrical production: 200 performers, drill formations that move like screensavers, a color guard throwing rifles into the stratosphere, props the size of sheds, and music that gets rehearsed 300 hours before you hear it. It is judged like gymnastics, scored like the Olympics, and in Texas it is roughly a varsity sport with better music.

Your grandkid is one of the 200, and their spot in every formation has a number, and they know all of them by heart. It's kind of amazing.

## The season, in one paragraph

Rehearsals start in the July heat. Friday nights are football games all fall, where the band plays in the stands all game and performs the show at halftime. Saturdays from late September through early November are contests, all-day affairs that can end near midnight. The best bands in Texas finish at the Alamodome in San Antonio in November. Then, because this family does things thoroughly, there's a second indoor season for color guard and percussion from December to April.

## How to see it

- **Easiest:** come to a Friday night football game. Halftime is the show, the stands are the atmosphere, and you'll be home by 11.
- **The real thing:** come to a Saturday contest finals. Night performance, stadium lights, and you will cry a little. Everyone does.
- **From anywhere:** big contests stream on FloMarching with a subscription, and the band posts videos on its [YouTube channel](#). Ask the parents for this year's links.
- **Photos:** parent photographers post galleries all season. Ask the parents for the link and the password.

## What to ask the kid

Good questions: What's the show about this year? What's the hardest set? Where are you on the field at the end? Can you show me the video?

Skip: "Did you win?" The answer is complicated and involves the word "caption." Ask "how'd it go?" and let them talk. They will.

## When to visit

October is the heart of the season, and a contest weekend visit means you actually see the thing they've built. November means the Alamodome, and yes, grandparents road-trip to San Antonio for it every year. Avoid planning anything during late July and August: band camp owns them, and you'd be visiting a very tired ghost.

## What to send, if sending is your love language

- Gas money or a gift card to the tea place. Trust us on the tea place.
- A snack box care package during camp or contest season. Addressed to the kid, raided by the section.
- Tickets: offering to cover a contest weekend or the San Antonio hotel is a grandparent power move.
- Show up once. That beats everything in a box.

## **The one thing to know**

This activity will eat their whole fall, and they chose it, and it is teaching them discipline, artistry, and how to function on six hours of sleep with 200 teammates. When they finally walk off that field in November, ask them to tell you everything. Then just listen.

*Part of the Texas Band Parent Playbook.*

# The Health Page

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*Heat, hearing, ankles, and sleep. Practical, sourced, zero panic.*

Band is safe, well-supervised, and physically demanding. These are the four things worth actually knowing, plus what changed in Texas this season. This page is information, not medical advice, and your kid's doctor and the school's athletic trainers outrank it.

## Heat, and the new Texas rules

New for 2026-27: UIL made heat safety protocols **mandatory** for all outdoor athletics AND marching band, effective August 1, 2026. Programs now monitor WBGT (wet bulb globe temperature, which factors heat, humidity, wind, and sun) within 15 minutes of practice start and every 30 minutes during, with required work-to-rest ratios and hydration breaks that scale up as readings climb, plus mandatory rapid-cooling zones on site. Translation: the days of "tough it out" are formally over, by rule, statewide.

What you control at home:

- The gallon jug leaves the house full. Every day. Electrolytes on two-a-days help, water alone is fine most days.
- Breakfast with protein before morning rehearsal. Kids who skip it hit the wall by 10am.
- Tell the directors about any condition (asthma, diabetes, POTS, medications that affect heat tolerance) before camp, not after an incident.
- Know the flags: cramps, dizziness, confusion, or a kid who stops sweating in the heat needs staff attention immediately. Programs drill this, kids should still hear it from you once.

## Hearing, the one nobody thinks about

A marching band at full volume runs well past levels hearing experts flag for extended exposure, and the kids standing next to the drumline get the worst of it, every rehearsal, for years. Occupational guidance starts flagging sustained exposure around 85 decibels, and rehearsal peaks blow past that.

The fix costs less than a pair of shoes: **musician's earplugs** (filtered, \$15 to \$40) drop the volume without muddying the music, which is why pros wear them on every stage. If your kid marches near the battery, plays in the front ensemble, or is IN the battery, put a pair in the band bag and normalize it. Hearing damage is cumulative, invisible, and permanent, and seventeen-year-olds discount all three of those words.

## Guard bodies

Guard is a throwing and catching sport performed on ankles and wrists. The predictable issues are sprains, overuse soreness, and the occasional catch gone wrong. The boring prevention works: shoes that actually fit, conditioning between seasons, taping habits the trainers recommend, and reporting pain when it starts instead of spinning through it for three weeks. "Push through" is a rehearsal ethic, not a medical plan, and the staff would rather hear about a sore wrist Tuesday than lose a performer in October.

## Sleep, the real currency

The season runs on borrowed sleep: early rehearsals, late games, 2am contest returns, first period regardless. Mostly, kids absorb it and are fine. What to actually watch: grades sliding, mood flattening, getting sick every other week. Those are the flags, not tiredness itself, because tiredness is the product.

Help the boring way: protect the no-band nights for actual sleep, feed them real food, and treat the post-contest Sunday as sacred recovery time. Skip the energy drink arms race, and if sleep problems look bigger than schedule math, that's a doctor conversation.

## The safety net that already exists

Texas schools staff athletic trainers who cover band, the new heat rules have teeth, physicals screen for the big stuff, and the medical history form you sign every year is read by real people. The system is built for this. Your job is the jug, the earplugs, the shoes, and the willingness to say something early.

## Sources

- UIL 2026-27 Heat Stress and Athletic Participation Required Plan
- Coverage of the new WBGT rules taking effect
- NIOSH on noise-induced hearing loss and hearing protection in marching settings

Checked August 2026. Not medical advice. Doctors and trainers win every tie.

# The Instrument Buying Guide

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*Rent, buy, upgrade, and the \$89 Amazon trap*

At some point someone will suggest your kid needs a better instrument, and you will have no idea if that's true or what it costs. This is the map.

## The ladder, in order

1. **Beginner rental** (middle school): rent from the school's partnered music retailer. Do not buy anything yet, half of sixth grade switches instruments.
2. **School-owned horns**: the big and expensive stuff (tubas, euphoniums, bass clarinets, bassoons, all concert percussion) belongs to the school. At FMHS the maintenance fee is \$100 a year, paid by separate check to FMHS Band, and LISD stocks professional-level instruments, so you never buy a tuba. Rejoice. Handbook rules: nobody plays anyone else's instrument, only percussionists touch percussion, and damage beyond normal wear bills to the student.
3. **The mouthpiece upgrade** (worth doing early): \$40 to \$150, recommended by the private teacher or director, and it improves sound more per dollar than anything else in this guide.
4. **The step-up instrument** (usually late middle school through 10th grade): an intermediate or pro-line horn for a kid who's clearly staying in the game. This is a real purchase, \$1,200 to \$4,000+ depending on instrument, and it should only happen with the director's or private teacher's specific recommendation of brand and model.

## The rules that save you money

- **Ask the teacher before the store.** Retail commission is real. Your private lesson teacher's used-market tip is usually the best deal in the building.
- **Used is fine, played-first is mandatory.** A used pro horn vetted by the teacher beats a new mid-tier one at the same price. Never buy an instrument nobody you trust has played.
- **The Amazon trap:** the \$89 "flute" and \$120 "trumpet" in the colorful listings are instrument-shaped objects. Repair shops refuse them because the metal doesn't survive the repair. Directors can spot them from the podium. If a deal looks impossible, it is.
- **Rental credit:** the school-partnered retailers often apply months of rental payments toward a purchase. Ask before you assume renting was sunk cost.
- **Repairs are local, with one rule first:** the handbook says check with a band director BEFORE the repair shop. The district-approved option is Music and Arts at The Shops at Vista Ridge, 500 E. FM 3040, Suite 121, Lewisville. Contest-week emergency repairs are a genre of miracle they perform weekly.
- **Instruments come home every night:** the handbook expects 30 minutes of practice a day and forbids leaving instruments in the band hall overnight. The nightly haul is policy, not your kid forgetting their locker.

## Insure the step-up

Once you own a \$2,500 saxophone that rides a school bus, insure it: either a rider on your homeowner's policy or a dedicated musical instrument policy (a modest annual cost, and it covers what school and homeowners policies often exclude, like the bus, the band hall, and gravity). Sharpie the case, AirTag the case, and photograph the serial number today.

## Percussion and guard, the short versions

- **Percussion kids don't buy drums.** The school owns those. They buy sticks, mallets, and a practice pad, roughly a monthly-allowance-sized habit. Marching sticks break, it's normal, buy the multi-pack.
- **Guard kids** get performance equipment through the program, but home practice gear (a practice flag, a practice rifle from a vendor like Designs by King) turns the living room into a rehearsal space. Budget for one lamp. It won't survive. It's a rite of passage.



## **What FMHS handles for you**

District instrument rentals and their fees run through Presto, uniforms are issued by the program, and the WISK announces retailer nights and repair drives when they happen. When in doubt, one email to the directors before any purchase over \$500. They answer this exact email fifty times a year and they would rather you ask.

Checked August 2026. Prices drift, the teacher's recommendation doesn't.

# Records and Receipts

What this program has actually done, with sources, plus the gaps you can help fill

New parents hear “this program is good” and nod politely. Here is what good means, in verifiable form.

## The trophy shelf, verified

| Achievement                                        | Years                             | Source                                   |
|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| UIL State Marching, GOLD                           | 2016, 2025                        | FMHS band site                           |
| UIL State Marching, silver                         | 2018                              | same                                     |
| UIL State Marching, bronze                         | 2020, 2024                        | same                                     |
| UIL State finalist streak                          | every state appearance since 2014 | same                                     |
| BOA Grand Nationals finalist                       | 2014, 2017, 2021                  | same                                     |
| BOA San Antonio Super Regional champion            | 2015, 2016, 2018, 2024            | same                                     |
| Macy’s Thanksgiving Day Parade                     | 2024                              | Cross Timbers Gazette                    |
| Midwest Clinic performance, Wind Symphony          | December 2026                     | per the band’s announcements this season |
| Color guard, WGI World Championships qualification | recent seasons                    | FMHS Color Guard                         |

Read that table again as a new parent: your kid walked into a program that medals at State, makes national finals, marched Herald Square, and sends its top concert band to the most selective stage in the band world, all in the last decade. The fee buys into that machine.

## What this means practically

- The staff and boosters have done every big trip and big stage before. When they say trust the process, they have receipts.
- Expectations are real. The program’s floor is high because its ceiling is.
- The younger siblings watching in the stands are watching a dynasty in progress. Cluster kids grow up wanting the swoosh shirt.

## Show titles by year, help us fill this in

Band people remember shows by name the way sports fans remember seasons. This table wants completing: if you know a year’s show title and theme, open an issue and we’ll add it.

| Season | Show title                           | The show in one sentence |
|--------|--------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| 2026   | <i>help us fill this in</i>          |                          |
| 2025   | <i>the State gold year</i>           |                          |
| 2024   | <i>the Macy’s year, State bronze</i> |                          |
| 2023   |                                      |                          |
| 2022   |                                      |                          |
| 2021   | <i>Grand Nats finalist year</i>      |                          |

## **Corrections welcome**

This page only lists what a source backs up. If you have a program (the paper kind), a photo of a trophy case plaque, or a FloMarching link that proves something belongs here, send it through CONTRIBUTING. Receipts beat memories, and memories around here are excellent.

Checked August 2026.

# The Middle School Pipeline

*For cluster parents of younger kids: how a sixth grader becomes a band kid, and how a freshman with zero experience becomes a weapon*

If you have a younger kid in the Flower Mound cluster, or a middle schooler wondering about high school band, this is how the machine feeds itself.

## The band path

1. **Fifth or sixth grade:** instrument selection. The middle school directors run fitting nights where kids try mouthpieces and get matched to instruments that fit their faces and the band's needs. Let the directors steer, they are building balanced bands years ahead.
2. **Middle school band:** beginner band, then advancing bands, with the cluster's middle schools feeding the FMHS program. The directors coordinate vertically, so what your kid learns in seventh grade is deliberately the on-ramp for ninth.
3. **Eighth grade spring:** the high school band comes recruiting: visits, joint concerts, and registration for the following fall. The physical, the fee, and the calendar from the starter guide all begin here.
4. **FM9:** freshmen are FULL members of the high school marching band while based at the ninth grade campus. Orientation gets coordinated around rehearsal (the WISK literally schedules around it). The kid you drop at FM9 in August performs at the Alamodome by November.

Two accelerators worth the money if you can: private lessons starting in middle school (the single biggest predictor of high school placement), and a decent step-up mouthpiece before a step-up horn (see the instrument guide).

## The guard path, which is different and shorter

Here is the secret nobody tells dance moms and gym parents: **color guard has no middle school requirement**. Guard recruits in the spring through clinics and auditions open to anyone, and kids from dance, gymnastics, cheer, and orchestra walk in with zero marching background every year. Movement training converts, fast.

Ours went from middle school orchestra to a world class guard's weapon line in three seasons. That path is open every spring. Watch for audition clinic announcements around March and April, follow @flomoguard, and show up. The guard will teach everything else.

## What to do by grade, the cheat sheet

| Kid's grade                    | Your move                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 5th                            | Attend instrument selection night, rent don't buy                                               |
| 6th and 7th                    | Support practice habits, consider lessons, go to their concerts, they notice                    |
| 8th                            | Spring: registration, physical, meet the HS program. Summer: relaxed, it's the last quiet one   |
| 8th, dancer or gymnast edition | Spring guard clinic. Just try it. The freshman guard class is built from kids who just tried it |
| Rising 9th                     | Read the starter guide, buy the jug, clear late July onward                                     |

## The honest pitch to younger-kid parents

The programs at the top of Texas marching are not assembled in ninth grade, they are grown from sixth. But the door stays open the whole way up: late-starting winds catch up with lessons, and guard rebuilds itself from newcomers every single spring. The machine wants your kid. Feed it.

Checked August 2026.

# Contacts and Connections

Every FMHS band contact and link in one place. The “who do I even email” page.

## The directory

People first, straight from the band’s published Parent Help Desk and the WISK. Where someone has both a band address and a personal one, both are listed, exactly as the band publishes them.

| Name                       | Covers                                                                                                    | Email                                                         | Phone                 |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| Mr. Willard                | Director: physicals, WISK list, Presto adds                                                               | willardt@lisd.net                                             |                       |
| Mr. Biskup                 | Head band director: private lesson scholarships (meet privately), 8-hour rule questions                   | via the staff page                                            |                       |
| Christin Casebolt          | Woodwinds section parent                                                                                  | caseboltc@lisd.net                                            | on the help desk page |
| Yoli Johnson               | Brass section parent, and the official “how do I get involved” human. Text her, that’s her published job. | cell and email on the help desk page                          | same                  |
| Stephanie Yost             | Percussion section parent                                                                                 | percussion@fmhsband.org                                       | on the help desk page |
| Angie Walker               | Color guard section parent                                                                                | cell and email on the help desk page                          | same                  |
| Kerry Mays and Mary Bowman | Boosters: away game meals and activities                                                                  | activities@fmhsband.org                                       |                       |
| Booster president          | The top of the parent org                                                                                 | president@fmhsband.org                                        |                       |
| Shoe crew                  | Marching shoe sizes and exchanges                                                                         | shoes@fmhsband.org                                            |                       |
| Julie Riekse               | Drumline liaison: jackets, fundraisers                                                                    | percussion@fmhsband.org for the section, personal in the WISK |                       |
| The directors, full roster | Band staff                                                                                                | Staff page, being added                                       |                       |

## Phone numbers

| Place            | Number                                    | Notes                                             |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| FMHS main office | (469) 713-5192                            | Ask for the band hall or fine arts, they transfer |
| FM9 campus       | (469) 713-5999                            | Ninth grade side questions                        |
| Campus address   | 3411 Peters Colony Rd, Flower Mound 75022 | FM9 is 3411-A, same property                      |

One reality check on phones: school lines sleep after office hours, and band life happens at night. On game and trip nights, the live channels are the app, the chaperone chain, and the parent groups, not the front office.

## Who to contact for what

| Your situation                    | Contact                        |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Physical forms, medical paperwork | Mr. Willard, willardt@lisd.net |

| Your situation                                                                              | Contact                                                                                                            |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Anything only a director can answer: placement, schedule conflicts, hardship help with fees | The directors, via the band staff page. Email beats everything else.                                               |
| Away game meals, dietary restrictions                                                       | Kerry Mays and Mary Bowman, <a href="mailto:activities@fmhsband.org">activities@fmhsband.org</a>                   |
| Marching shoes: sizes, exchanges, missing pairs                                             | <a href="mailto:shoes@fmhsband.org">shoes@fmhsband.org</a>                                                         |
| Booster questions, sponsorships, donations, “who runs this”                                 | <a href="mailto:president@fmhsband.org">president@fmhsband.org</a>                                                 |
| Drumline: jackets, fundraisers, section logistics                                           | Drumline liaison Julie Riekse, personal email in the WISK                                                          |
| Guard: uniforms, schedules, section questions                                               | Guard liaisons answer in the BAND app, ask there first                                                             |
| Not receiving the WISK                                                                      | Mr. Willard, <a href="mailto:willardt@lisd.net">willardt@lisd.net</a> . Include your name and your student’s name. |
| Locked out of the Facebook parent group                                                     | You have to be in Presto first. Not in Presto? Email Mr. Willard, then request the group again.                    |
| “I want to help but I don’t know how much time I have”                                      | Text Yoli Johnson, 972-822-6347. She talks it through, no commitment required.                                     |
| Corrections to this playbook                                                                | Open an issue, or find the guard dad in the pickup line                                                            |

## The escalation ladder, so you use it in the right order

1. Check the WISK and the app (Presto for band, BAND for guard). It’s answered there more often than not.
2. Ask the parent Facebook group. Someone hit your exact problem last year.
3. Ask the relevant liaison.
4. Email the role address from the table above.
5. Email a director. They answer, they’re just also teaching 430 kids, so give it a day or two before a follow-up.

One etiquette rule carries this whole page: email, don’t DM. Staff and booster officers live in their inboxes, not their Facebook messages.

## The AMA, the boosters’ best onboarding trick

Summer Thursdays, the boosters run Ask Me Anything: board members and veteran parents post up in the band parking lot for the last hour of evening practice and take any question, no matter how new-parent it feels. Their words: band is a lot, you are not alone, we have all been there. Show up once with your dumbest questions and leave with a section parent’s cell number and half this playbook confirmed in person.

## Every official link, one shelf

### The program

- [fmhsband.org](http://fmhsband.org), the band site: FAQ, packing lists, pickup procedures
- Band staff and directors
- Boosters page, the master link list
- FMHS Color Guard

### Daily operations

- Presto Assistant, roster, forms, fees, the WISK
- BAND app, the guard’s channel
- Band Google Calendars, all three, with phone sync steps

### School and district

- Skyward Family Access, grades and enrollment
- RevTrak, school-side payments

- Rank One, physical and medical forms portal
- VOLY, the volunteer background check, link arrives via the WISK
- LISD athletics tickets, football home games

### **Money and merch**

- Band merch store
- Guard merch store
- JotForm and SignUpGenius links rotate per event, always via the WISK or the groups

### **Media**

- SmugMug photo galleries, password in the WISK
- YouTube, Instagram, Facebook page, X
- Guard: @flomoguard

### **The parent side**

- FloMo Guard Parents group
- FloMo Band Parents group, ask any member for the invite (joining requires being in Presto first)

## **The blanks worth filling**

The full staff roster with names and titles belongs in the table up top. If you have the current list from the [directors page](#) or a booster officer roster from a recent WISK, send it in and this page becomes complete.

Checked August 2026. Roles rotate every spring, the WISK announces the new cast.

## Forms and Quick Links

*The fridge page. Every form you'll be asked for and every link you'll actually use.*

### The forms, and when they bite

| Form                             | When                                                         | Where it lives                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| UIL physical                     | Before camp, new for every student this season               | Upload via the band's form, questions to willardt@lisd.net. District athletics side runs through Rank One |
| Medical history form             | Every year, signed by parent and student                     | Comes with registration                                                                                   |
| Online registration plus deposit | July, makeup nights in August                                | Password-protected page on fmhsband.org, password in the WISK                                             |
| Away Game Meal Form              | Due August 21, required for EVERY student                    | Link in the WISK, questions to activities@fmhsband.org                                                    |
| Dietary Restriction Form         | Due August 21, also required for every student               | Link in the WISK                                                                                          |
| Marching shoe reply form         | August, everyone answers yes or no                           | JotForm link in the WISK, exchanges via shoes@fmhsband.org                                                |
| Band photo order                 | Early August, discount deadline is real, no makeup photo day | JotForm link and discount code in the WISK                                                                |
| VOLY background check            | Before you volunteer for anything, takes up to 2 weeks       | LISD VOLY portal, link in the WISK                                                                        |
| Volunteer signups                | All season                                                   | SignUpGenius links in the WISK and parent groups                                                          |

The pattern worth learning: permanent forms live on the band site and Rank One, seasonal forms arrive as JotForm links in the WISK, and volunteer shifts run through SignUpGenius. When in doubt, search your email for WISK first.

### Quick links, the top shelf

| Link                  | What it is                                                      |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| fmhsband.org          | The band site: FAQ, packing lists, pickup procedures, help desk |
| Presto Assistant      | Roster, forms, fees, the WISK                                   |
| Band calendars        | All three, with phone sync steps                                |
| Skyward               | Grades and enrollment                                           |
| RevTrak               | School-side payments                                            |
| Rank One              | Physical and medical forms portal                               |
| LISD football tickets | Home games and the Hebron away game                             |
| Band merch store      | The good stuff                                                  |
| Guard merch store     | The guard's good stuff                                          |
| SmugMug galleries     | Season photos, password in the WISK                             |
| FMHS Color Guard      | Guard site                                                      |
| FloMo Guard Parents   | The guard parent group                                          |
| Band YouTube          | Show videos for the grandparents                                |



| Link                          | What it is                  |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| This playbook's contacts page | Who to email, call, or text |

Seasonal JotForm and SignUpGenius links rotate, so they're deliberately not pinned here: the current ones are always in the newest WISK, condensed weekly in the digest.

Checked August 2026. The band's own Parent/Student Links page is the canonical version, this one just loads faster in the pickup line.

# Lettering in Band, the One-Pager

*Yes, band kids letter. Here's how that works.*

## The short answer

A varsity letter in band is a real varsity letter, same jacket rack as football. In Texas programs, band kids typically earn it faster than parents expect, because the activity is scored, adjudicated, and time-intensive enough to satisfy any lettering standard ever written.

## The LISD system, exactly

Straight from the 2026-27 FMHS Band Handbook. Two ways to earn the letter jacket purchase:

1. **Finish junior year** while continuing into senior year, automatic.
2. **Bank 10 points in one school year**, any year, including freshman year.

**Achievement points** (reset to zero every school year):

| Achievement                                           | Points |
|-------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| Region band placement and event participation         | 4      |
| TMEA Area advancement and audition participation      | 3      |
| TMEA All-State placement and participation            | 2      |
| First Division, Class 1 solo (LISD Solo and Ensemble) | 3      |
| First Division, Class 1 ensemble                      | 3      |
| First Division, Class 2 solo                          | 2      |
| First Division, Class 2 ensemble                      | 2      |

One solo and one ensemble count per year. Alternates only earn points if they're moved into the actual event.

**Membership points:** 2 per completed year in good standing. Freshmen start at 0, sophomores at 2, juniors at 4, stackable with achievement points.

The math that matters: a freshman who makes Region (4) and pulls First Division on a Class 1 solo (3) and ensemble (3) letters in year one. A junior enters the year with 4 banked and needs one good audition season. The ladder is climbable early, which is exactly why the directors push All-Region and Solo and Ensemble so hard.

## The jacket itself

- The earned price is about **\$45 for the basic jacket and letter** at the district rate through Texas Chenille, the district's vendor. Add-ons and customization cost more and stack up over the years, budget for those gradually.
- **Fittings happen on campus in May**, directors hand the vendor the point totals, and families pay Texas Chenille directly.
- **Delivery lands in the first nine weeks of the following school year.** Letter in spring, jacket in fall. Nobody warns the kids, so warn yours.
- Order a size up. They wear hoodies under it, and ideally they wear it for decades.
- Fine print from the handbook FAQ: academic ineligibility can cost points if it blocks the event, and transfer students can earn on the same criteria.

## The part that isn't about the jacket

Watch a kid put on a letter jacket with a band patch on it and try to argue marching band isn't a sport. The jacket ends arguments at family dinners, walks into twenty-year reunions, and eventually hangs in a closet where a grandkid finds it. Worth every form it took.

Source: the 2026-27 FMHS Band Handbook, LISD lettering policy section. Vendor details at [texaschenille.com](http://texaschenille.com). Checked August 2026.

# Contributing

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This playbook gets things wrong sometimes, and fees, rules, and dates drift every season. Corrections beat pride here. Help.

## How to help

- **Easiest:** open an Issue on this repo describing the fix (“the guard fee changed,” “Region is a different Saturday,” “the tea place changed its rewards program”). A link or photo as proof settles everything instantly.
- **Comfortable with GitHub:** open a pull request against the page. Small and factual merges fast.
- **Neither:** tell the maintainer in the parent groups. It’ll get here.

## What belongs

- Facts with sources: dates, costs, links, rule changes, corrected names.
- Plain English. Write like you’d explain it in the pickup line.
- Year-stamps on anything that can drift (“as of fall 2026”).
- FloMo specifics and general Texas knowledge both welcome, labeled as whichever they are.

## What doesn’t

- Anything about specific kids. No student names, no placement gossip, no “which freshman got moved.”
- Private contact info. Role emails yes, personal numbers and addresses no.
- Passwords, door codes, and discount codes. Family channels carry those.
- Drama. There is no drama section. There will never be a drama section.
- Criticism of staff, judges, or other programs. The internet has other venues.

## House style

No pep talks, no purple prose, no em dashes. Blunt and kind. Jokes dry. Sources at the bottom. If a sentence would embarrass you read aloud in a booster meeting, cut it.

## The tiebreaker

When this repo and the WISK disagree, the WISK is right and this repo has a bug. Say so, we’ll fix it.

Maintained by a guard dad who learned all of this the hard way, with an AI assistant doing the typing.